



ESCUELA DE INGENIERÍA
FACULTAD DE INGENIERÍA

Lecture 11: Essay writing

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ICS2523 Microeconomics

Lecture 10

Last lecture we started learning

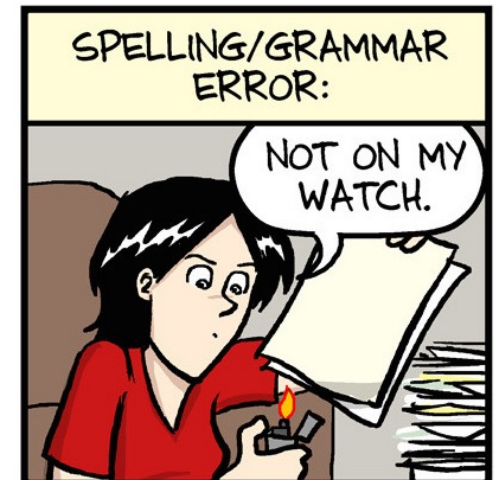
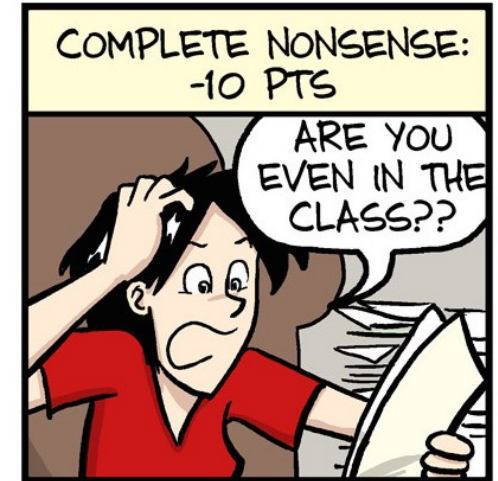
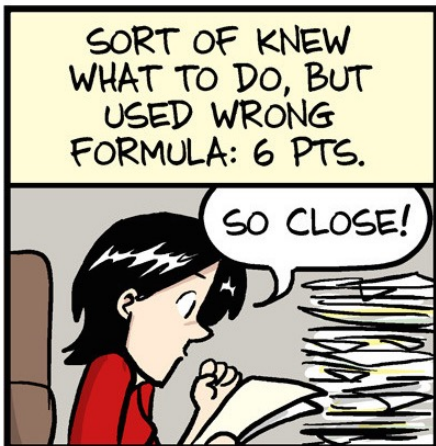
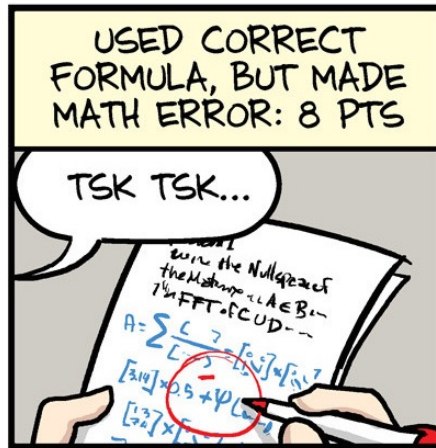
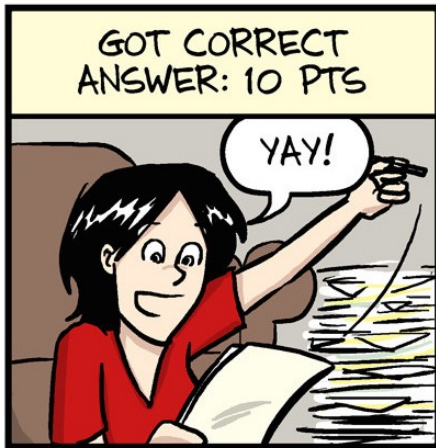
- Producer Theory

In today's lecture we will

- Learn some tips on essay writing
- Learn how to write more effectively

GRADING RUBRIC

PROBLEM 1 (TOTAL POINTS: 10)



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Essay Writing

Microeconomics

Why is so important to write an essay?

In real life, you will have to write. If you are not effective in your writing skills, you will lose a lot of time (and other people's time too)

A good essay should reflect that you:

- **Understood** what you read
- Are capable of **critical thinking**
- Can **organise your ideas** logically

Five steps to write a good essay

1. Interpretation of the question
2. Research
3. Planning
4. Writing
5. Revision

1. Interpretation of the question

A common mistake is to rush into our research (anxious to get on the work)

- As a result, we read sources and take notes without a clear idea of what is relevant → waste of time

The first step is to **understand what the question is getting at**, and what the teacher is looking for in our work.

1. Interpretation of the question

Before starting our research → Analysis & Brainstorming

- Think about your analysis of the issues presented in the question
- Write down your ideas
- Test your ideas
 - Find examples that reflect the concept you are thinking and analyse their core characteristics, those common to your examples.
 - Also, find a borderline case, something that doesn't fit in
 - You can also look for a contrasting case or even a doubtful case
- Brainstorming: Empty your mind and write everything you might know about the subject

2. Research

Remember: we are **reading with a purpose** → of answering the question

You will have several sources of information

- Teacher's recommendations

- Bibliographies

- Journals

- Newspapers

- Government reports

- Internet (scholar google)

- Specialist databases

Process your ideas

- Identify the key elements → and write them down

- Analyse and criticise what you read

3. Planning

You are now in a much better position to meet the demands of an essay that asks you to use the higher cognitive skills: to **criticise**, **discuss**, and **evaluate** a claim or an argument.

Planning an essay is the most important stage, yet the most neglected

- A plan gives your essay a clear structure for examiners to follow as they navigate their way through ideas and arguments that are unfamiliar to them
- **Even your weakest argument gains strength in planning**

3. Planning

Planning means that you must:

- Think about the **essay's structure** so your reader doesn't get lost in your arguments
- **Present arguments** that are clear and consistent
- Have **sufficient evidence** to support them
- Make sure **all your arguments are relevant** and you haven't omitted something important
- Think about it as a **MAP ROUTE**: you may order and edit
- Remember: the introduction and topic sentences at the beginning of each paragraph are the directions guiding the reader at each change of route.

4. Writing

Passive or active voice?

In general, **active voice** should be preferred **unless what is done is more important** than who did it.

What is an **Active** voice?

The sentence has a subject that acts upon its verb

Example: **I** ate a slice of pizza

What is a **Passive** voice?

Sentence where a subject is the recipient of the action

Example: The **slice of pizza** was eaten by me

4. Writing

Passive or active voice?

We have to identify the important thing we are trying to communicate → **Identify the subject.**

Once we know the subject, if he is the doer of the action, we must write an active sentence.

If the subject is the receiver of the action, you must write a passive sentence.

WARNING: we tend to overuse passive...

Activity 1

Identify if the sentence is in active or passive voice and try to write it better:

- My first car will never be forgotten by me.
- Professor Jenkins and Dr Taylor of University College London last month achieved the most significant breakthrough yet in the treatment of colon cancer.

Below are pairs of statements. Rewrite each pair into a single sentence in either active or passive form. Choose which you think is the most appropriate in each case, and briefly give your reasons for your choices.

- Alexis Sánchez scored the goal. The decisive goal was scored in the last minute of the game.
- Chief Justice Taylor was driving home. He was stopped by the police and found to be driving under the influence of alcohol.

4. Writing

To write good introductions, paragraphs, and conclusions we need to know:

- The plan of the essay: its structure and content

- What we are trying to achieve when we write them

Simple is elegant

- Sentences should be as short as possible

- Use simple words → do not look up complex language, use the right word

Clear and effective writing depends upon thinking clearly

4. Writing

The first time you write your ideas do not edit, just write

Then you will edit

Possible essay's structure:

Introduction + Body + Conclusion

Introduction =
theme A +
theme B



Paragraph
(theme A)



Paragraph
(theme B)



Conclusion

4. Writing: Introduction

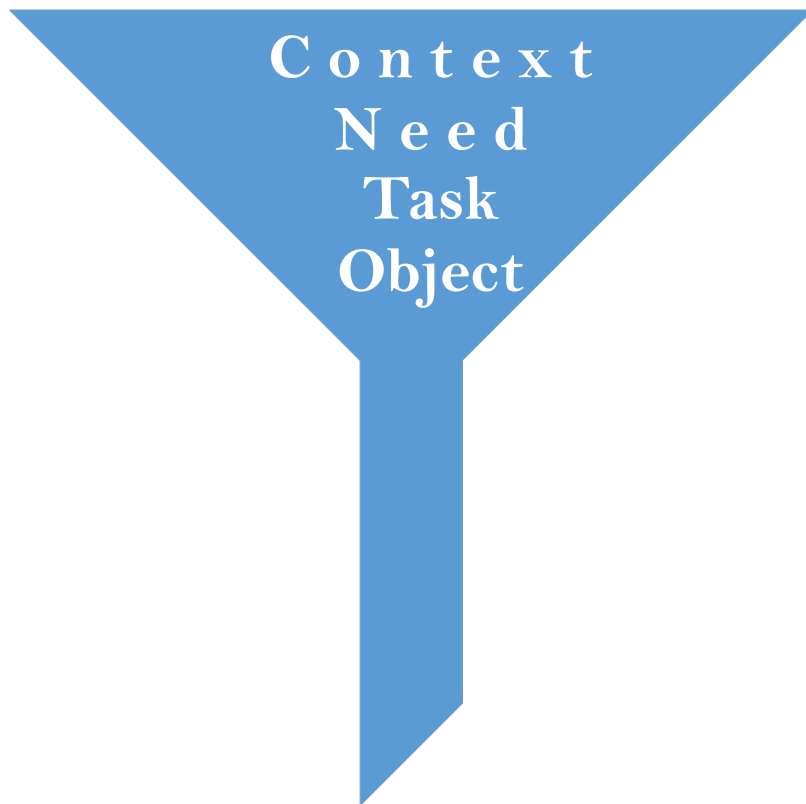
The introduction must start with a context where you present the question.

The introduction must be clear on:

- Interpretation of the question

- Answer's structure

The **introduction** has the shape of a funnel:



- **Context:** why the need/question is so pressing or important. It gives enough information to understand the need.
- **Need/question:** What needs to be addressed.
- **Task:** What will be done to address the need
- **Object:** what the present document does or covers

4. Writing: Body

The **body** is the paragraphs between the introduction and conclusion. Ideally, you should link every paragraph with central ideas already exposed in the introduction → **cohesive piece of work**

Introduction =
theme A+
theme B



Paragraph
(theme A)



Paragraph
(theme B)



Conclusion

4. Writing: Body

In **every paragraph** reader should understand:

- Why its central idea is relevant

- What are you doing by writing that paragraph

Try to avoid essay that reads like a loose list of isolated points

Let the logic of the plan dictate the length of each paragraph

Paragraphs usually have three parts:

- Topic sentence – Development - Evidence

4. Writing: Body

To create a cohesive piece of work, each paragraph needs to have a clear connection with the one that preceded it → use **transitions** at the beginning of the topic sentence

Contrast → in contrast, however, but, on the other hand, yet

Extension → moreover, similarly, furthermore, in addition, by extension, what is more

Illustration → for example, for instance, that is

Reinforcing → similarly, likewise

Conclusion → therefore, consequently, as a result, thus

The next step → then, after that, it follows

4. Writing: Body

There are MANY more: likewise, correspondingly, hence, accordingly, nevertheless, incidentally, otherwise, nonetheless, obviously, etc.

ATTENTION: if you are using too much of transitions like *also, another point is, in addition, after, then, the next* (and so on) it means you are not longer discussing issues by developing critical analysis. Instead, you have slipped into a description of the issues.

4. Writing: Conclusion

What should I do in a **conclusion**?

- **Give your opinions?**

The opinions you express in the conclusion must reflect the strength and balance of the arguments that have preceded them in the body of the essay

- **Summarise the main points of your essay?**

Yes, you may do that, but we are expecting more from you

- **Pick up the theme/question raised in the introduction?**

YES!!! It will show a cohesive piece of work by picking up the theme you raised in the introduction

- **Present wider implications or future trends/lines of investigation?**

YES!!!

4. Writing: Conclusion

You must try to achieve ONE thing in the conclusion:
**wrap up the essay leaving your readers
satisfied that they have read something
worthwhile (sense of discovery)**

5. Revision

Take distance / Cooling off→ Never start editing just after finishing writing. You must separate the writer from the editor.

It is very hard to take distance from one's work. Ask for a friend to read your work and accept their comments with humility.

5. Revision

You shouldn't revise all at once. Revise more than once, focusing each time on different things:

Structure

Check that you can read your essay “fluently.”

Revise the structural features of your essay (introduction, conclusion, and logical structure)

Content

Remove all unnecessary words and phrases likely to obscure the meaning of your sentences → important words will stand out.

Make sure your meaning is being carried out by strong nouns and verbs (rather than too many adverbs, adjectives, and prepositions)

Make sentences simpler, more direct and concise (use active voice)

5. Revision

To edit different things, you need different types of friends:

Clarity → someone who is not specialised in the field of your essay

Precision → someone specialised

Grammar and spelling → someone who knows about it

Whenever you ask for help in editing, always

Tell them **what you are expecting** → otherwise, they will focus on correcting your grammar and spelling

Tell them **when** you need their revision.

Be receptive, not defensive

5. Revision

Try to express your ideas clearly, and concisely, with economical use of words

- Remove all unnecessary words that obscure the meaning of the sentence
- Eventually, you will stop using these words 😊

Activity 2

Read these sentences and write them down with fewer words

- “In order to create a wireless network you must have a router and a laptop computer acting as a server”
- “For that reason it is important to understand the factors that may impact the....”

Bonus 1: Referencing

BONUS: Referencing + Plagiarism

- There are a lot of different systems governing the way we cite references.
- You should get familiar with one most used in your field (APA)
- Whatever you choose, you should be clear, accurate, and consistent
- **AIMS → give credit to our sources and give sufficient detail for our readers to follow them up**

Bonus 1: Referencing

In-text citing → when you *paraphrase* an author's words, only the author and the year need to be included:

- One author: Certain diets that reduce ... violence (Valzelli, 1981)
- Two authors: Certain diets that reduce ... Violence (Valzelli & Gómez, 1981)
- Three or more: Certain diets that reduce ... Violence (Valzelli et al., 1981)

or

- One author: Valzelli (1981) argues that....
- Two authors: Valzelli and Gómez (1981) argue that.....
- Three or more: Valzelli et al. (1981) argue that

Bonus 1: Referencing

Bibliography or Reference list:

- **Book:**

Baumol, W. y Oates, J. (1988) *The Theory of Environmental Policy*, Second Edition, Cambridge University Press.

- **Chapter of a book** (usually when the book is a collection of chapters written by different authors):

Jones Lee, M. (1994) Safety and the savings of life. In R. Layard y S. Glaister (Eds.), *Cost - Benefit Analysis*. Cambridge University Press, Cambridge.

- **Thesis:**

Fridstrøm, L. (1999) *Econometric Models of Road Use, Accident, and Road Investment Decisions*. PhD thesis, Institute of Transport Economics, TØI report 457/1999, University of Oslo, Oslo.

- **Article from a journal:**

Boyer, M. y Dionne, G,. (1987) The economics of road safety. *Transportation Research B* 21, pp. 413-431.

Bonus 1: Referencing

Bibliography or reference list:

- **Article from a conference:**

Hojman, P., Ortúzar, J. de D., Rizzi, L.I. (2003) El valor de la reducción de accidentes fatales y no fatales en carreteras. *XI Congreso Chileno de Ingeniería de Transporte* Conference Proceedings, pp.515 – 528, Santiago.

- **Web page:**

Wilde, G. (2000), *Enhancing Workers' and Drivers' Interest in their Own Safety*. En
<http://www.maa.nsw.gov.au/professionals/safety/Gerald_Wilde.PDF>.
Accessed in XX/YY/ZZZZ

- **Report from a consultant for a public body:**

CITRA (1996) *Investigación Diseño de Programa de Seguridad Vial Nacional*, for Ministerio de Transportes y Telecomunicaciones y Ministerio de Obras Públicas.

Bonus 1: Referencing

- Bibliography or reference list:
 - **Report from a course that it is in the library:**
Alcoholado, G., Castro, M., Loewe, I y Lopez, S. (2003) Plan de reducción de accidentes en cruces ferroviarios a nivel. Mimeo, Evaluación Social de Proyectos. Departamento de Ingeniería de Transporte, Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile.
 - **Personal interview :**
Beltrán, M. (2006) Personal communication.

The bibliography should be ordered alphabetically according to the surname of the first author.

Further help may be found in:

<http://guiastematicas.bibliotecas.uc.cl/normasapa>

Bonus 2: Plagiarism

What is plagiarism?

We must acknowledge all those who have helped us by giving us materials in the form of ideas, quotations, figures, and anecdotes.

→ Plagiarism is dishonest and will be punished and treated as a serious offence.

Why is plagiarism bad?

- We are **stealing intellectual property**.
- There is **little educational value** in doing so. Copying work and making it our own avoids the task of processing these ideas → avoids learning.

Bonus 2: Plagiarism

Plagiarism is taking credit for work that is not yours

- Most of it comes because we are unaware of the rules of acknowledgement
- Students who rush through their notes and fail to restructure what they read (or express it in their own words), are most likely to plagiarise
- They leave insufficient time to process the ideas and rework them without referring back to the original

BONUS 2: Plagiarism

When to cite?

- Whenever an author has given a distinctive idea
- Whenever an author has given a distinctive structure or organising strategy
- Information or data from a particular source (facts, statistics, tables, diagrams)
- Verbatim phrase or passage → quotation marks + italics and cite the source
- If it is not common knowledge
- Whenever in doubt, cite it!

Activity 3

Which of these statements is common knowledge?

1. The French Revolution began in July 1789
2. 34% of all journalists believe that official government sources cannot be relied upon
3. Quantum mechanics deals with the motion and interaction of particles
4. Einstein once said, 'God is subtle, but he is not malicious.'
5. All public companies have an obligation to submit their accounts to an annual audit.

Individual Activity

In a piece of paper write down **2-3 concepts** that you learnt today. Please write down the concept and what you learnt about it, in your own words.

If you have any **questions** about we discussed today, write it down too. We will go through them at the beginning of next class.

Finally, if there is a word you didn't understand, write it down so it can be part of the **glossary**.